I unbent and said, rather snappishly (for it had been a long day and I was tired), "I'm lifting as much as I can."

"You mean that's all you can lift?" He at once lifted a pile twice as high as the one I was trying to handle. "Look at that."

And without much in the way of forethought, I said, "We're not all alike, Private. I've got a strong mind and a weak back."

You'd be surprised how amiss he took that simple statement. He didn't have a mind so weak, unfortunately, that he missed the implication.

I was promptly set to cleaning out the grease trap, which was supposed to be a very terrible job because it induced nausea. I managed.

5

The next day we had our first inspection.

In the old days, I had never been deft in the laboratory. Now I was never deft in inspection.

We were carefully told how to make beds so tight that a quarter would bounce off the blanket if dropped on it. No quarter alive ever bounced off any blanket I touched.

We were also taught to clean our rifles with a greased patch and a ramrod in order to get out the accumulated rust. My rifles invariably manufactured rust and no grease patch ever emerged unstained from any rifle barrel I put my hand on.

Eventually I learned to name every part of a rifle and to disassemble and assemble one even in the dark, but if I ever had an unrusted rifle barrel I was unaware of it.

I was in a constant state of terror that I would be punished in some vague way for having blankets on which quarters did not bounce or rifles in which rust could be sighted. The loss of furlough privileges was the least of it. My imagination conjured up visions that were more along the line of being drawn and quartered.

Hikes were another source of insecurity. We were all supposed to march briskly, with our rifles on our shoulders slanting in a perfectly vertical